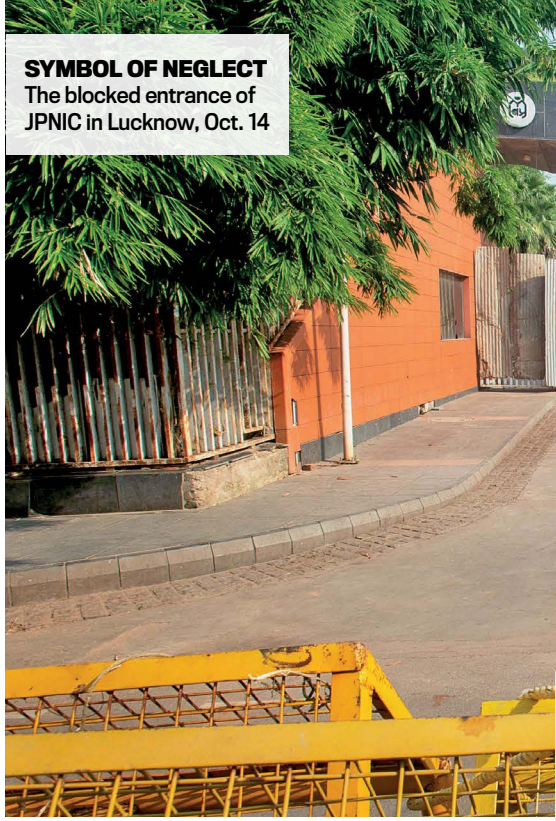


SYMBOL OF NEGLECT
The blocked entrance of JPNIC in Lucknow, Oct. 14

Photographs by VVOM A

CAUGHT IN THE POLITICAL CROSSFIRE

SEVERAL FLAGSHIP PROJECTS FROM THE SAMAJWADI PARTY ERA, INCLUDING IN YADAV REDOUBT SAIFAI, REMAIN UNFINISHED. FUNDING SHORTAGES AND CORRUPTION PROBES ARE CITED AS REASONS, BUT OPPOSITION IS ANGRY

BY ASHISH MISRA

'Lok Nayak' Jayaprakash Narayan would probably be turning in his grave. An expensive, under-construction project in the heart of Lucknow, named in his honour, has become a battleground for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Samajwadi Party (SP), both of whom hold the socialist icon in great esteem.

On October 11, the birth anniversary of 'JP' saw high drama in the UP capital. Nothing like last year, though, when SP president and former chief minister Akhilesh Yadav jumped the gate of the Jayaprakash Narayan International Centre (JPNIC) to garland his statue, causing a stir. To prevent a repeat this year, the administration sealed the gate with tin sheets and implemented tight security there, as well as at Akhilesh's home and the party office on Vikramaditya Marg. But hundreds of SP workers braved the police presence and assembled near his residence in the morning. JP's statue was brought out by the police on an open jeep, converted into a stage, for Akhilesh to pay tribute. He told the gathering, "The BJP is stopping us from entering JPNIC by claiming there are scorpions inside. The truth is, there are many scorpions in its own government."

If nothing else, the controversy shone a torch on the dozen or so development projects that were launched during the SP government from 2012 to 2017 but remain unfinished. The flagship JPNIC has been under construction for over a decade. Spread over 18 acres in Gomti Nagar, the multi-functional JPNIC was initiated by former CM and SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav in 2013. "Initially, the cost proposed by the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) was Rs 421.93 crore, which was estimated as Rs 265.58 crore by the Expenditure Finance Committee. After this, the game of budget revision started. In 2014, the budget was increased to Rs 615 crore and, then in 2015, to Rs 757 crore. For the third time, in November 2016, the cost was revised to Rs 865 crore," BJP spokesperson Alok Awasthi says. "The SP government released Rs 821 crore, which has been spent. Despite this, the work could not be completed."

In October 2016, Mulayam inaugurated a part of the project. The construction work progressed rapidly till 2017 but after the Yogi Adityanath government took power that year, the then minister of state for housing Suresh Pasi alleged corruption, which was investigated thrice during 2017-18. Many officers, including the LDA's then vice president, chief engineer and finance controller, were held guilty, but no action has been taken against anyone till now. SP national general secretary Shivpal Yadav says, "The BJP government has discriminated against